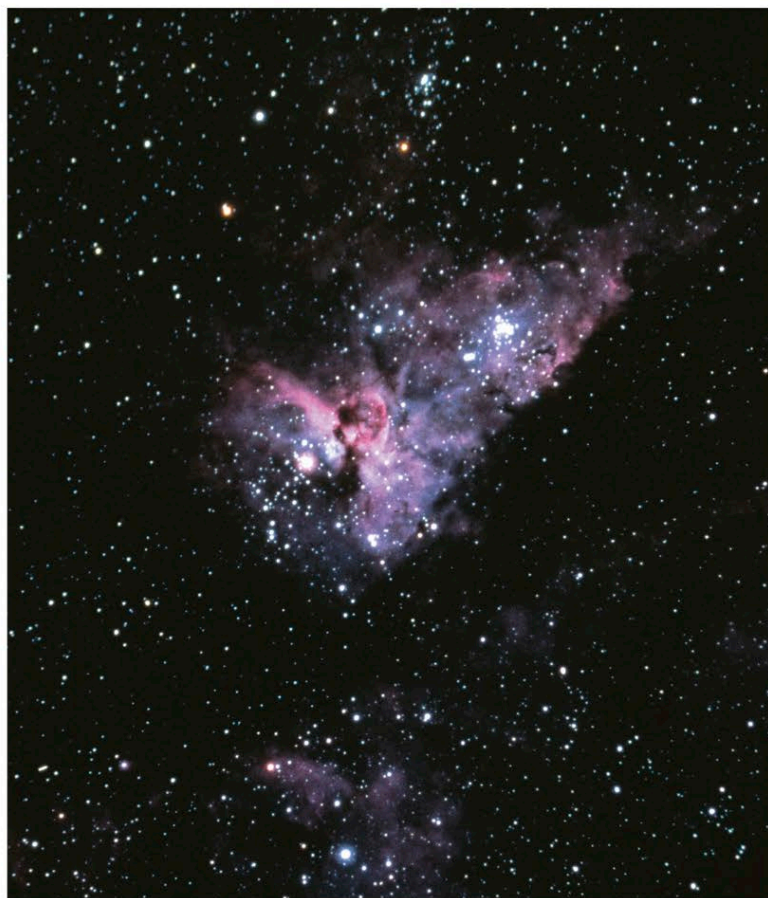




THE CARINA NEBULA

This huge nebula in the southern Milky Way is visible to the naked eye. Eta (η) Carinae (center left) is a peculiar variable star that is surrounded by a glowing shell of gas.

SOUTHERN LATITUDES

THE STARS

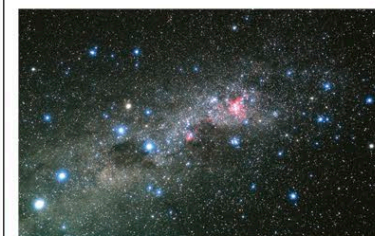
In the Southern Hemisphere, Crux lies almost on the north-south meridian line, with Rigil Kentaurus (see p.252) and Hadar—Alpha (α) and Beta (β) Centauri—slightly to its lower left. Antares, in Scorpius, is rising in the southeast, while Canopus, in Carina, sinks low in the southwest. Hydra's long body meanders overhead, its head adjoining Cancer in the northwest and its tail ending between Libra and Centaurus in the southeast. Spica, the brightest star in Virgo, is high in the east. Leo lies in the north, with Arcturus, in Boötes, in the northeast. Observers north of latitude 40°S can see the Big Dipper low on the northern horizon.

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

Next to the Southern Cross, an apparent gap in the rich stream of the Milky Way is visible to the naked eye. This is, in fact, a dark nebula, known as the Coalsack, which obscures the light of the

background stars. On its edge is the Jewel Box cluster (see p.294), or NGC 4755, which looks like a hazy star to the naked eye.

On display in Carina is the cluster IC 2602 and the Carina Nebula (see p.247), or NGC 3372. To the east, among the rich star fields of Centaurus, is the globular cluster NGC 5139 or Omega (ω) Centauri, which looks like a hazy 4th-magnitude star. In the north of the sky, members of the Virgo Cluster are well placed for telescopic observation this month.



THE COALSACK

This dark cloud of dust (center left), next to the Southern Cross, is silhouetted against the bright background of the Milky Way.

